

在希望的上 田野

ON THE FIELD OF HOPE

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WANG QINGSONG



策展人
CURATOR
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2020
07.11-08.26

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当代唐人艺术中心
TANG CONTEMPORARY ART

Press Release

Wang Qingsong Solo Exhibition

“On the Field of Hope”, July 11 – August 26, 2020

Address: Tang Contemporary, B01 & D06, 798 Art District, NO.2 Jiuxianqiao Road, Chaoyang District Beijing, China.



Billboard, 170x300cm, c-print, 2004

Tang Contemporary (Beijing) is honored to announce that an important exhibition of artist Wang Qingsong "On the field of hope" will be held in its two spaces from July 11, 2020 to August 26, 2020. Curated by Cui Cancan, the exhibition shows more than 30 important photo and 2 video works as well as a documentary of the making of Wang's major pieces in the past 20 years since 1999.

“On the Field of Hope” takes its name from a popular song in the 1980s, which extolled the transformations of that era and forecast a promising future, and most significantly, inspired Wang Qingsong when he was young.

As one of the most important artists in Asian photography, Wang has built a body of work based on the dramatic shifts in Chinese culture from that times. He pioneered a narrative for photography in the 1990s encompassing a post-modern vocabulary, large-scale staged sets, and a vernacular aesthetic that opened the viewer's perspective to the ironies embedded in a consumer-oriented

material world. Today, he continues to blend the techniques of painting, theater and cinematography to create multi-layered stories which extend the boundaries of Chinese photography and alter the perspective of traditional Western photography.

Through socially impactful imagery, Wang's body of work showcases the tension between changing societal realities and human desires, and imaginatively presents the ongoing drama that hovers between fields of the past and hopes for the future.

Four decades have passed since songs like "Young People Meeting" gave a youthful generation a sense of optimism. Wang Qingsong's interconnectedness with and temporal distance from those popular songs give rise to nostalgic recollections as well as discussions of destiny and historical realities. Looking back on those memories and stepping into the future, the artist tries to bridge the idealistic 1980s with the current pandemic in 2020.

On this field of hope, we bring together past and future, and look to new dreams.



Forum, 120x210cm, 2001

For more information on the exhibition:

Check on this link: <https://www.tangcontemporary.com/2020-onthefieldofhope-en>

Media Coverage



Work, work, work, 180x300cm, 2012

1. Phoenix Art News coverage: <https://mp.weixin.qq.com/s/puf9sEhcrUngK9P8RT0iGw>
2. Hi 艺术 https://mp.weixin.qq.com/s/nL_fTqsMGBM8CzhwFmO36A
3. CGTN : <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=aZ9vtqiE4LE>
4. 凡是摄影 : <https://mp.weixin.qq.com/s/0DIbkeZX5Wkf2v-MIQqSng>
5. 南方人物专刊: <https://mp.weixin.qq.com/s/WGW469Y7NgSK4nMQjUUJIQ>
6. 知声学长 : <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=pD8Y4rdg71M>
7. 一条 :
8. 澎湃新闻 :
9. 瑞丽摄影 : <http://v.rayli.com.cn/2020-07-31/20200731232901.mp4>
10. 798 艺术展评 : <https://mp.weixin.qq.com/s/pajAdRNzUSgern-1bJmswQ>
11. 凡是摄影 : <https://mp.weixin.qq.com/s/0DIbkeZX5Wkf2v-MIQqSng>

12. 优看：<https://mp.weixin.qq.com/s/xlwlysFwWFgkDR7aN6kZCQ>

13. 开眼：

14. 北京青年报：

15. 长江文艺：

“On the Field of Hope”

Cui Cancan (curator), July 5, 2020

Click here to see [Cui Cancan's Tour of the Exhibition:](#)

(I)

In 2000, Wang Qingsong pioneered a new way of narration. With the opening and closing of a handscroll, the center of the story in “Night Revels of Lao Li” constantly moves, highlighting a flowing and fragmented narrative. Inspired by a historical allusion to a Chinese traditional painting, Wang converges multiple sets of intertwined scenes from different times and places without hierarchical order. As a result, a new vision and comprehension of viewing and understanding this world changes the history of Chinese photography and alters the perspective of traditional photography in the West in the last century.



Night Revels of Lao Li, 120x960cm, 2000

For Western viewers, “Night Revels of Lao Li” has the historical charm of a distant China, while for Chinese viewers, it was the earliest representation of a post-modern vocabulary in photography which diverged from the past narratives. Beginning with “Night Revels of Lao Li”, Wang Qingsong brings together this mode of storytelling in his distinctive narratives and grandiose stage sets and embarks on a new historical journey. A single image becomes a triptych. A triptych develops into a handscroll. A handscroll evolves into a panoramic stage play. All these incessant adjustments activate and expand the functionality of photo narration. Since then, photography has no longer generated an isolated shadow of reality. It becomes a vast and confusing archeological site that has countless links to reality.

In Wang’s grand tableaux, the decisive moment featured in traditional photography becomes a continuous moment. He provides a continuous imagery to a certain moment and combines several dozen typological photographs into the same picture. Single pictures become multiple images which evolve into an album and further into a collection of images through interplays with stage sets. In “Romantique” and “China Mansion”, Wang re-engages with the narrative functionality of multi-point perspective, exerting the specific advantages of handscrolls which interpret complex historical stories. As nearly one hundred models are portrayed as classic figures in the Western art history from hundreds of years ago, the temporal sequence is broken, and the spatial structure is reconstructed.

Compared to traditional documentary photography, Wang Qingsong does not use a camera to record a moment in reality. Rather, he shows the real background that produces this moment. His method is additive, not subtractive. Beginning with a momentary feeling, he pursues to develop into a scene inside a story at a historical period. In “Dormitory”, Wang concentrates on producing

one single image which will be produced by traditional photography over a couple of years. Dozens of metal-framed beds give metaphors to dozens of different real spaces, loaded with “real food for thoughts” like one big shipping container. They symbolize different families or stories. Here, space is condensed, and time is drawn closer. “Dreams of Migrants” brings different family dramas onto the same stage, where the ups and downs of these seventy-two “tenants” play out. This unique arrangement and composition offer a “God-like perspective.” Any acts in this play seems to denote everything under this world. However, Wang does not take on a “God-like perspective” in order to look down on these people; he directs our eyes and imaginations from less to more, from more to the infinite, then to broader and more expansive symbolism.



Dormitory, 170x400cm, 2005

Deviating from traditional photographers, Wang Qingsong plays different roles and identities at different stages in producing one single work. At the very beginning, he is like a playwright or author who conceives of a text and determines a rough story. Later, like a painter, he makes sketches and engages with further details. Sometimes he has to plan on postures, gestures, placement, and costume for several hundred figures. It might take him six months to meticulously paint the logos stroke by stroke that need to be photographed. All of these seemingly repetitive and boring tasks must be completed before the real thing, from locating a suitable setting, building stage sets, dispatching actors and large numbers of props and etc. He is just like a film director. He has to make one adjustment after another to the sets, shifting focus from the whole to the parts and from the parts to the whole. In this process, these source materials from the reality will be transformed into specific figures and scenes of varying magnitudes. At every step, he has to confront mistakes, reconfigure loss of control, forecast unforeseen changes and calculate constant increasing expenses and appropriate times/places.

It takes quite a lot of time to ensure that all of the pieces are in place in the puzzle. Then he sets up his camera and waits to take the picture. The poses and expressions of the actors must be captured before they fleet away. The light and shadow reveal all kinds of subtleties. He must take shot of the “decisive moment” which involves a huge production cost. Inside the black box of the camera, the light refracts information which turns into his artistic reality and realistic history.



Requesting Buddha, 180x110cm, 1999



Bequeathing Buddha, 180x130cm, 2019

Wang Qingsong is more like an artist in a Hollywood studio, managing a large team and countless details, and handling different kinds of tasks and processes. Sometimes he needs hundreds of people through teamwork on a set of several thousand square meters. Sometimes he prepares for one photograph in a number of years, waiting for the right moment. He constantly shifts between these different roles and times. Photography does not carry its own power through a separate medium. Rather it must work in concert with other media to convey more nuances.

Therefore, impactful visuals are connected with legible information in Wang Qingsong's work. The forms no longer require explanation, and the mixture of text, theatrics, and cinematography brings out the best of these media. The imagery provides irrefutable evidence. The text provides clear information and possible direction. The stage provides the relationship between locations, backgrounds, and characters. Such cinematic vocabulary connects these shots in the same scroll and rehearses at the same time and space one drama after another.

This makes Wang Qingsong's works easy to understand, giving it an independent presence that does not require further explanation. In the pictures, he reveals the times, places, major protagonists, and arranges interconnectedness between the temporal backgrounds and narratives.



Dream of Migrants, 170x400cm, 2005

To analyze his work is like uncovering a film. One can decipher these steps. In his celebrated piece “Follow Me”, an immense visual impact attracts the eye, offering a magnificent visual spectacle. Second, we are attracted to densely-packed forms, colors, and shadows, which start to activate our experience to recognize certain information. However, this information cannot be grasped at a glance, and its meaning cannot be comprehended immediately. This large volume of information transforms looking into a voyage of exploration and discovery. This new journey for the viewer gives viewers a delight in reading and discovering. At that point, viewing becomes a game compelling us to uncover the answers to these riddles that the artist has left in unobtrusive corners amidst numerous objects.



Follow Me, 120x300cm, 2003

Imitating a camera's observation to the world, one first looks at the overall whole, then moves toward a visual center. Here one follows the artist's eye. The lens constantly shifts, scanning its relationship to the surroundings. A row of large slogans, several obvious erased marks, and a few grammatically incorrect English sentences and seemingly familiar symbols pull us into relationships with complex storylines as he tries to identify similarities and differences from the

reality. What are they saying? Who is the person in the middle of the image? Where is the pointer directing? What is written on the blackboard? What is the relationship between these texts and the final image? What is this work trying to say at last?



Follow Him 130x300cm, 2009

Confronted with so many Wang Qingsong's photo works, we experience a process that John Berger described—from looking to seeing, from seeing to gazing and examining. Finally, we extract ourselves from the reading of visual information and the searching of meanings. In the face of a series of question marks, we begin to wonder, in this long trajectory of the artist's career, why does the discussion of education reappear? Why are texts or slogans always prominently highlighted in his narratives? Or, none of this is important. What the heck the artist has such a miraculous hairstyle!



Follow You, 180x300cm, 2013

There is no riddle to unpack the story of “Follow Me”. He is not preaching, and he is certainly not following conventions. In Wang’s work, there is no final answer telling you that the world should be a certain way. He is simply consolidating his experiences and feelings, and constantly questioning reality, asking why something happens in this way or that way. In his later works such as “Follow Him” and “Follow You”, the trilogy pushed the story into a larger historical background or a larger reality. Wang develops one work into a series and then moves from that series into a richer message. The pieces echo one another, questioning and authenticating each other over the course of a decade. Exactly like a long series of novels, or an epic film, he keeps on exploring the myth.

Beginning in the late 1990s, Wang Qingsong embarked on a new path to creating “meanings”. He abandoned the grand tradition that photography once cherished, and reconnected photography to reality in order to present another charm that reality bears in photography.



Ethereal Beauty, 120x280cm, 2003



Auspicious Snow, 120x280cm, 2003

Before the photographer presses the shutter, the world that he sees and understands is entirely different from the fragment that the viewer sees in the exhibition hall. Here one grasps everything while the other only sees a part stripped of its beginning and end. John Berger wrote, “here lies an insurmountable chasm or abyss between the moment that the photographer records and the moment that viewers see.” Although some aspects of this abyss are part of the self-discipline and advanced aesthetics of modern photography, this ambiguity has been appreciated by many traditional photographers. Deviating from the constraints of this genre, Wang Qingsong builds a bridge out of the multiple languages in painting, theatrics, and cinematography to remedy momentary deficiencies and add the threads of a beginning and end to the story.



One World, One Dream, 180x225cm x 2 pieces, 2014

However, he does not stop at the functionality of documentary photography. His work situates doubt, criticism, and satire within those falsified yet real scenes. What we see seems to be real, but the absurdity of conflicting details and relationships is so incongruous. The models' half-hearted performances and indefinable sense of isolation remind us that this is a drama play, which carries deeper visions and metaphors. Therefore, as reality becomes more distant, the image metaphors of reality becomes more prominent.

Wang has to keep some distance from documentary photography, which refers to captures reality directly. Temporally and spatially, he relies on a calmer and more rational state from which to observe and understand the overall social relationships before he can pronounce his comprehensive statement. He creates a concept at first, then fills in with minute details from complex reality. Therefore he is “creating” stories rather than describing them.

Reality is simply a source of materials and photography is just a means to an end. The objects he photographs are stylized (fabricated) yet typical events, existing in reality, but not completely. Wang photographs reality, e.g. a mark left by a drop of water or a ruin left by transformation. However, this reality does not provide proofs as it is. Rather, it comes from the artist's individual reflection, or his stance in the face of such crude reality. His photographs come from reality, but are the products of cultural programming, creating a more fresh and refined “melodrama” or “sensation”. However, this “sensation” is more realistic than texts, enriched with more spices.



Fotofest, 170x300cm, 2005



Competition, 170x300cm, 2004

(II)

Across this society, all have been changing, but not the concept of family. The living situations of these “petty people,” and many other facets of society, are ubiquitous in Wang’s work. His perspective is that of the commoners that examines keenly and empathetically, analyzes social psychology and portrays how these people see the world. They have their own ideals and hopes,

their own joys and sense of beauty, even though this beauty may be hated by those with “good taste.” In the grand torrents of history, they float along, drifting from left to right, in ill-fitting clothes. They make great efforts to catch up, but they are always a few steps too late. They have a full load of doubts, attempting to make themselves look not so “messy”. But they always exude awkward hybrid features from this epoch. Regardless of how reality has changed or how irresistible globalization has been, there is always a group of people that has nearly caught up but always have been left far behind. Wang’s photographs are for these petty people, bearing witness to the strictures of human nature.



Debacle, 180x300cm, 2009

Wang Qingsong has captured a historical storyline at the most special locale, where cities and townships meet and produce its unique cultural traits for the social transformations in the last decades. In this world, he discovers a distinctive aesthetic, drawn from his hometown, an ancient city called Jingzhou, Hubei Province in 1980s to the construction workers’ sheds in Zhumadian, Henan Province in 1990s, onto the low-priced marketplace in Yiwu, Zhejiang Province in 2000s, continuing to the outskirts of Baoding, Hebei Province. Now all these forces come to the place where he has been living since 1993, a border land merging into a megacity. These relocations look like alternative utopias, including Yuanmingyuan Artists’ Village, Tongxian Township, and Victoria Bay in the dim light of Caochangdi Village. In these places, he saw rising franchises, KFC and Mr. Lee (formerly California Beef Noodle King), permeating all over small townships, enriching life for content and happiness. There one finds commoners’ life philosophy oriented towards power to survive and inextinguishable hope towards fragmented reality. It is full of grief and joy, typical of a life for the vast majority of people.

His work reflects a popular aesthetic with a post-modern perspective. Through a common person's eye, it bids farewell to the glory of modernism, the God's All-mighty glorious moments, or the sacred aura of light and shade. This not entirely "graceful" taste largely preserves the direct perception into reality itself. His aesthetics and methods are populist and democratic, and they are more in keeping with an era of ubiquitous advertising and internet connection, floating up and down with the times and populace's tastes. In other words, only by reversing the power of advertising and consumerism with the same enforcement in the form of photographic "menace", can he exert the full power of the social and historic function of photography in such a reality.



MOMA Studio, 170x300cm, 2005

This artistic nourishment might come from his earlier experiment with gaudy art, a methodology based on learning from popular culture and folk art. We can easily capture a historic aesthetic in his works, combining a grand collectivism, realist literary narratives, formalistic folk taste, as well as Chinese illustrations, storybooks, political propaganda images, and mass model plays from the 1970s and 1980s.

(III)

In 1981, the song "On the Field of Hope" spread all over China. Along with "Young People Meeting" and "Youth, Youth," people enjoyed the changes in that era and looked for a beautiful prospect for the future.

Far away in the small town of Jingzhou, Wang Qingsong was living another life. His father died on a job mission. Gradually more depressed, he could not envision a future for himself. The song "On the Field of Hope" and the environment at that time were immensely meaningful for ending

that dark period in his life. The joyful musical vitality and infectious lyrical power tell a simple yet attractive story, awakening the new generation of the 1980s and encouraging Wang to participate in these significant changes.



Goddess, 180x250cm, 2011

Wang Qingsong enrolled in an art college in the early 1990s. He arrived in Beijing in 1993 to begin his life as a “migrant” artist. In 1997, Wang shot his first series of photo works and gave them rather interesting titles such as “Take Up the Pen, Fight Until the End”, “Old and Young Soldiers”, and “Our Life is Sweeter Than Honey”. The frank and popular style and the stories of life alluded to in popular songs were echoed for the first time in his work. Later, Wang’s lens record the endless changes in Chinese society, and his artworks condense the histories, enlive the memories, and detail the transformations of reality and human desires. In between hope and field, his endless drama premieres.

The unprecedented 2020 pandemic suddenly stopped this accelerated social machine. Likewise, the questions that Wang Qingsong has been asking stop suddenly, as those models in his works freeze his attempt to untangle puzzles. The thread of the story is severed once again. The story about globalization and consumerism, connecting China to the world and helping the world to understand China which carries the sense of “life is as sweet as honey” and “tomorrow will be better” are temporarily brought to a close at the turning point of 2020. We don’t know when the pandemic will end, as we wonder into a river without coordinates and lose the orientation to comprehend these new changes. Old stories have collapsed, with new stories of hope yet to come.



Preschool, 120x160cm, 2002



On the Field of Hope, 180x300cm, 2020

“Question a Brick Wall” is a new work in 2020 which summarizes the past puzzles and merges the previous two seminal works into a new force. In terms of form and content, this new work fuses “Competition” and “Debacle” from 2004 onwards and carries onwards the advertising and textual elements that repeatedly appear in “One World, One Dream” in 2014, thereby continuing the consumerist spectacle, a core theme in Wang’s work. Semantically, the large question mark reveals his vision that has been woven into the works made in the last two decades. Beginning with “Can We Cooperate with You?”, doubts and suspicions about the world permeate in every work. When it appears with a hefty scale of a monument in an exhibition space, the work asks a particularly important question at this moment, because all historical times and markings have started once again. We don’t know if the future will simply fall into the void, or if it will break through the dark abyss to welcome the entirety of stars.



Question a Brick Wall, 280x180cm, 2020

The title of the exhibition, “On the Field of Hope,” represents the past, the future, and a new hope. Where is our future? Where is our field? This question has started since the 1980s. After the massive changes in the last four decades, herein again we confront the past. If we have not experienced these decades, or if the temporal and spatial distances have not made the details of history ambiguous, those tears on the field of hope, drifting crowds, charming evenings, short-lived joys will not clarify the vision, or sharpen the dramas before they vanish into a vacuum. But at the very least, Wang Qingsong’s photography leaves us with a series of long shots. He believes that the human history is as simple and short as a long roll of photo paper.

That same young man who lost his life’s direction in Jingzhou in 1981 finds his answer on the field of hope. Forty years have passed as the song “young friends meet” goes on. Wang Qingsong’s interconnectedness with and temporal distance from those pop songs inspire recollections and hopes, as well as generate discussions of human destiny at such realities of different eras. As we look back on those memories and look forward into the future, we try to bridge the idealistic years of 1980s and the current pandemic in 2020. Sometimes we feel abrupt cutthroat pain out of the blue, but disasters seem to have been foretold, depressing though worth pondering for survival strategies .

Some Thoughts on my Solo Show "On the Field of Hope"

--- Wang Qingsong, July 21, 2020

My solo exhibition "On the Field of Hope" opened smoothly on July 11, 2020 at Tang Contemporary. Surprisingly it succeeded out of my expectation at this time of pandemic. I think I should thank many artists around me and friends from my community. Of course, the success is also inseparable from the support of Tang Contemporary. Without its help, it would be difficult for this exhibition to open smoothly. Without its support, the new works might not have been completed successfully.



王庆松工作室

In fact, this exhibition was decided a year ago among myself, the curator Cui Cancan and Mr. Zheng, owner of Tang Contemporary. It was planned to open in early July 2020. I thought this time would be appropriate as school holidays fall in early July. My children studying abroad would be back then. I hope they all can come to the opening of my solo exhibition. But what I didn't expect was that the epidemic starting in Wuhan before 2020 Spring Festival ran rampant, and caused an outbreak across the world. At the beginning, I felt it would not be so serious and it would pass quickly, maybe end soon in a month or 40 days. However, it becomes a pandemic, much more serious, spreading into all corners of the world. What is gratifying now at least, is that the contagion is slowing down and our life is slowly returning to normal.

When I first talked to Cancan, the curator for this exhibition, we were not so sure of the theme yet. The original title would be "Wang Qingsong Solo Exhibition". During the making of "Question a Brick Wall", we decided that this title of the new work would be the theme of the exhibition. After I returned to China from the U.S. in late January 2020, the coronavirus caused serious disruption to my preparation. It last longer and prevented me from going out. I realized that a lot of things will be affected by this pandemic and nothing became predictable. Homebound, I started to prepare this new work "Question a Brick Wall".



Wang Qingsong working on the ads for the photo shoot

At the beginning, I just wanted to practice calligraphy. I chose some cheap advertising paper I used to write and scribbled some brands and their advertisements collected over these years. When I realized that this pandemic would not be over within a short period of time, I began to write in a neater manner, thinking of a new way to present this work in the exhibition that would open on July 11. As I said, the theme of the exhibition would be the title of the work "Question a Brick Wall". This work was actually not as easy as making "Competition" in 2004 or "Debacle" in 2009. This time I was not writing calligraphy, but rather drawing and painting calligraphy and logos in more clarity and detail. I must draw each one over and over again, and paint many times one layer on top of another layer. In total, I did about 400 pieces of advertising paper within four months.



Mapping the ads in Wang's studio

The height of the entire wall is set according to the height of the gallery space in Tang Contemporary. The installation is 8.3 meters and the width is almost 5.4 meters. On this huge poster wall, there are nearly 1,000 corporate brands, mainly those of Fortune 500 companies. The rest are some most recent popular product brands on the Internet, some common ones in our lives, including logos of art galleries and cultural institutions, and several brands from my hometown Jinzhou, Hubei Province. There are also my favorite and commonly used product brands. It took me more than four months to hand paint all these advertisements. Everyday I lay on the table for more than 10 hours. I sat on the sofa for so long that “carved” out a big hole into the sofa. My presbyopic glasses changed from 100 degrees to 300 degrees. So it is not exaggerating at all to say that I spent a great deal of time and energy into making this work.



Cui Cancan, Wang Qingsong and Cui Jian





王庆松工作室

Here I want to address more briefly about the change of the title of the exhibition, which is from "Question a Brick Wall" to "On the field of Hope". This change occurred along with the outbreak and spread of the pandemic in 2020. In the meantime of preparing for "Question a Brick Wall", I was working on shooting another new work. Originally, I wanted to make an installation in the old space of Tang Contemporary after I finished the shoot of this work. This second work talks about intense examinations to get into an art academy, or simply, it is a work critiquing about education in general. In the beginning, the title of this work was not "On the Field of Hope" at all. I could not finalize its name, probably I would call it "art exam class" or "rocket class".



王庆松工作室



王庆松工作室

Chen Weiqun, Wang Qingsong and Liu Haizhou

At the end of May 2020, there appeared a second spike of COVID-19 in Beijing. The return made me suddenly feel more concerned how I could finish this work, leaving me worried and suspended of whether this exhibition could proceed smoothly. As scheduled, in the old gallery space of Tang Contemporary, I would like to show this new work and a scene from shooting this work. But I doubted if this work could be finished on time due to the second spike of this severe virus. As the opening the exhibition approached, there was not much time left to shoot this new work. I must make a quick decision where to shoot this work as there was very little time, more than one month only, left to open the exhibition.



Three drafts (Plan A, B and C) due to COVID-19

Originally, it was scheduled to be shot indoors, inside China National Film Corporation's film studios in Huairou Township. I planned to rent a studio there. But after I went there, I learned that it would be impossible to shoot indoors because this work would require 500 people to enter the scene. During the lockdown, organizing 50 people to shoot indoors would not be allowed. Being caught off guard, I must give up my indoor shooting plan. After discussing with the curator, I decided to shoot outdoors. After I made the decision, I drove around to find a suitable shooting location. In the end, when I saw an outdoor scene, I found it not so bad at all. However, I didn't give up. I still wanted to find other indoor venues. So, I asked private studios in Daxing Township if they allow for 500 people to shoot indoors. Finally, after rounds of communicating with so many people, I learned that no one in charge dared to approve so many humans doing indoor activities during the pandemic. So, I aborted the original ideas.

In the end, I could only choose to shoot outdoors, hoping to complete this work successfully as this work would be the highlight for this solo exhibition. Then I went to Fangshan Township

again to see this outdoor venue. That day I went, it was overcast and grayish, just like the gloomy mood of people under the second wave of epidemic in Beijing. The sky gradually turned orange when driving back to the studio. At sunset, I looked outside the window and "On the Field of Hope" resonated in my mind. I switched on the phone and played this song. Along with the melody, I imagined the outdoor shooting scene, and decided to name the work "On the Field of Hope". Firstly, I hoped that this work could be completed smoothly. Secondly, I wish the exhibition would be opened successfully.



Details of Plan B and C for shooting "On the Field of Hope"

(YouTube) [Click to see the Making of "On the Field of Hope"](#)



Wang Huangsheng is sketching a portrait



Wang Qingsong/Cui Cancan/Liao Wen/Li Xianting

I went back to discuss with the curator, Cancan, telling him that the theme of this exhibition needed to be changed. During this long period of lockdown, each of us has experienced such a complicated and conflicted mood of disturbance. I wondered if we could give the audience a sense of hope. Such a hope reminds us of the popular song "[On the Field of Hope](#)" that I often

listened to after I graduated from my middle school and entered a high school in the 1980s. This song with its lyrics and melody encouraged me in the 1980s when I was a youth.

I remembered the parallels in the lyrics very clearly, “My hometown is on the field of hope; my ideal is on the field of hope; my future is on the field of hope”. These three hopes gave youngsters so much encouragement at that time. In the midst of this pandemic, we all need a tiny bit of hope too, even if it is a hope with some doubt and controversy. Talking with Cancan, he also felt the same. Therefore, we finalized the theme of the exhibition, "On the Field of Hope", which reflects the history awaiting a better future at this abrupt crossroad. Under such hardship, we must ask about where the future holds for us. So it was almost before I shot this work that we determined the title of the exhibition and also that of this work as "On the Field of Hope".



Speaking of the work itself, from the onset of shooting indoors to outdoors, I always wished that 500 people participate in the work. Even if it would be an outdoor shooting, I still hoped that 500 people would stand still in the picture, as it was conceived from the very beginning. But once coming to terms with the reality of shooting outdoors, I found it impossible for people to appear in the composition. On second thoughts, I felt that no one appearing in the photo shoot might have another unexpected effect and achieve a much better impact. Just like what we see in the exhibition now, there are only 500 easels and nearly 500 sketches. None but I appeared in the photograph. The shooting day was again overcast which created a special atmosphere for the work "On the Field of Hope", exactly the kind of feeling I needed.



Wang Qingsong is processing the portraits



On the Field of Hope, 180x300cm, 2020

It would be super difficult to finish the shoot without the help of my friends. During the epidemic, I could only shoot in the mountains on the outskirts of Beijing, more than 100 kilometers away from Beijing. I'd need a lot of people to help set up the easels on the scene. The

accommodation, food and drink, and the transportation of people were very cumbersome. Especially Fangshan Township was relatively close to the place where the second wave of epidemic broke out. Only friends, trusting me, not much concerned about coronavirus, would join me as they risk being infected by the virus through working outside with many people.



Chen Weiqun/Wang Qingsong/Liu Haizhou

After three days of hard work, the shoot went smoothly from its onset to completion. Although working outdoors was super hard and many people got sunburned, everyone was as happy as going for an outing. It is worth mentioning that I was so afraid of rain, rain, and rain before and during the shooting. If it rained, all my sketches would be ruined. However, there was no rain at all during these three days. Right after returning to my studio, a sudden downpour overshadowed Beijing for a long time. I thought I was very lucky. At that time, I believed that my exhibition will be opened in good luck.

Of course, I am very grateful to all the friends who helped me complete the shoot so smoothly. In addition to the support from friends helping with the shooting, I also have to thank all the students and teachers, artists/friends who sketched my portraits, especially Xi'an August 1st Art School, Lanzhou Zhengshang Studio, the Attached School to Qinghua Art Academy. Thanks should also be extended to people from 798 street painters, Taobao salespersons, and Weibo fans, which increased the styles of the sketches.



Zong Ning and Wang Qingsong



Wang Qingsong prepares for "Question a Brick Wall"

After shooting the photowork "On the Field of Hope", the hand-painted project of "Question a Brick Wall" was finished by working around the clock. After completing these two new works, it was June 28th. There were about ten days left before the exhibition opened. The entire process from post-production, printing photo works, and framing/mounting dragged along. In fact, at noontime before the opening day of the exhibition, some of the first framed works were delivered to the gallery and the installation started to be in place. It was not until the second set of works arrived at 6pm later that all the works were successfully placed on the wall. I have to thank for the contribution by all the staff who worked overtime for the framing and installing the show at the two gallery spaces of Tang Contemporary.

The preface of this exhibition was also finalized after communicating the overall exhibition layout with the curator Cui Cancan, which included my art works made from 1999 to 2020. We decided to present the preface in the form of handwritten blackboard written with colored chalks. I invited a great artist friend Lei Tong to hand write the entire preface. The two spaces have two walls, and the writing was so time-consuming. I tried out a little bit of writing but felt so painful on my shoulders hanging there. Therefore, a special gratitude should be given to Lei Tong for his great help in the process of setting up the exhibition prefaces.



Lei Tong is using chalks to write the preface.

After the exhibition was installed, I had new worries again. Before the second spike of the epidemics, 798 art districts had slowly begun to return to its former bustle. Upon its return, people suddenly became vigilant. During the first few days of setting up the exhibition, I found little traffic in the entire 798 Art District. Less than ten people visited the gallery space a day. Throughout the evening, I was worried about the opening of the next day. Will there be anyone showing up the next day? Will the opening go smoothly? Everything was unknown as I expected a very difficult opening, without reception or a dinner party after the opening. Due to the special situation of the pandemic, I did not send out any personal invitations to my relatives and friends. I just posted a simple message about the exhibition on Weibo and WeChat before the opening.

The next day, I went to the gallery after lunch and waited for the opening in the afternoon. When I arrived at the gallery, I found that all these worries were actually unnecessary. The opening was far better than my imagination. Many friends living in Beijing came to the exhibition one after another. Even some old friends who have not seen each other in the past ten years showed up. Many of them told me that this was the first time they came to 798 to see an exhibition this year. I was very happy for this result, full of thanks for these friends to visit my exhibition during this extraordinary moment. It is my great honor. This was an opening ceremony of an unusual exhibition, the one without an opening ceremony, without food and drinks during the reception. However, it was the most memorable opening for me during the epidemic. The only regret is that my children could not come back to see my solo exhibition as they were stuck overseas.



It has been ten days since the opening of the exhibition. During this period, friends come to see the exhibition constantly. Of course, I will occasionally introduce this exhibition to my friends. The exhibition "On the Field of Hope" has also attracted a lot of attention and report by some media. I am also very grateful to these media interviews and reports, as well as the spread of news by my friends on Weibo and WeChat. I personally posted the exhibition information on Weibo, which received a lot of attention and reposts from fans. After ten days, the number of readings of the exhibition information on Weibo has exceeded 500,000. It is beyond my expectation to be able to receive such immense attention. Thank all my fans for their long-term support. Thanks again to all the friends who helped this exhibition. My sincere appreciation goes to a lot of people.

What is gratifying is that two days ago, Beijing officially announced that the emergency response has been reduced from level two to level three. Nationwide, cinemas have officially opened up again. Just like the theme of this exhibition "On the Field of Hope", I think our future is still full of hopes. I myself still hold dear hopes for the future.

Finally, I would like to thank Cui Cancan, curator of this exhibition, "On the Field of Hope". He is also a great neighbor.



Logo of Wang Qingsong Studio

WANG Qingsong

“It is more important if my artworks become social illustrations

Instead of entering art museums.” by Deng Yu, Nanfang People’s Weekly



image courtesy of Jiang Xiaoming

"At a certain time, if you are better than some Western photographers, they will not believe in you, and some might stop you. Think about it! We might have learned the surface when we first studied the West. Probably we misunderstood and misread the West. After a long time, we realize that these learnings collide with our own foundation. Nowadays, this young generation go overseas much early and learn the best of the West. But I'm afraid they will be at a loss after learning. So, what is the next step?"

As if on the bare ground, many thin columns that were not straight stick out crookedly from a chimney. It is hard to distinguish where the chimney pillars are, and where the smoke comes out. But there is this three-dimensional effect. Looking closer, one sees a pile of sparse weed, each of which tilts towards the sky, but never droops.

Walking closer to the 8.3 meter tall by 6.4 meter blue background of a "big headed photo" on the gallery wall at Tang Contemporary, one bursts out, "Wow, it's really hair."



Wang Qingsong and Cui Cancan

The face of the man in the photo is swarthy and shiny, as if he is a fitness contestant with concentrated tung oil on his face. The bloodshot eyes are shedding sad condensed tears. Oversize, solemnity in dark suits, white shirts and red ties are swept away by the grotesque hairstyle, bringing laughter to everyone whoever sees it. Looking at the picture again, every "future art candidate" has to draw such an interesting person. The sketches collected on site and in the original works are really surprising and humorous. The tongue-in-cheek banter directed by

the artist was tacitly "colluded" by painters and viewers whom the artist had no intention of choosing.

This work originally wanted to invite 500 students (models) for participation. Due to 2020 Coronavirus, he had to forgo this idea and photoshoot only empty chairs in the outdoors.



During installation, this scene of art examination is “moved” to the gallery. The ID photo that every student sketched was enlarged on the wall. The final photo work is placed on the opposite wall. Viewers are invited to try out sketching on the easels.

It is obvious that the superficial intention of the work "On the Field of Hope" directs towards art academy tests and unified art education model. But this is only one of the many loaded expressions. Everything else is silent, illegible and unspeakable.

Wang Qingsong, with his typical "Chimney Hair", is recognized in the art circle as a pioneer in Chinese conceptual photography although he does not accept this label at all. Over the past 20

years, he has been noted for constructing large scenes, using large format camera, creating high definition images, inviting models to stage dramatic narratives that relate to "like fake but real" scenarios as his identifiable markers.

His photos are well-presented in exhibition halls. The models wearing "unpopular" costumes and weird makeup, for example, in "Night Revels of Lao Li" (2000) unfold an unclear story through unrolling a scroll of five-frame movie still. In "Follow Me" (2003) and "Question a Brick Wall" (2020), he condenses massive amounts of information from different times and spaces into one single frame. Looking at his photos is like playing "scavenger hunt". A familiar LOGO, a bundle of wigs or exposed dentures, a book in his hand, and small objects in a pile of rubble challenge viewer's acute vision, picking out and guessing the artist's pre-embedded "Threads".

He often portrays himself as a peasant, worker, teacher, patient, scribbler, vagabond or an unidentified person, quietly hiding in his photos. Wang Qingsong plays the role of a "director", an actor and a voyeur, all in one.



Those models, props, and Wang Qingsong himself in the photographs and outside the lens contribute together to completing his mission, with full heart and mind, to record the grotesque, absurd and painful epoch and eroded humanity. His greatest hope is that his work can become a social illustration (in newspapers and magazines) in the future ---"This is more important to me than entering an art museum."



Straightforward and gaudy

Entering Tang Contemporary (two gallery spaces), one finds coherence between the collection of sketches installed in the big open space and the contemporary photography scenario depicted in "Fotofest" (2005) at a smaller space. In the second gallery, the installation of multiple panels for shooting his latest work "Question a Brick Wall" (2020) stands like a monument in the center, reproduced from delineated symbols, logos and advertisements of commercial brands that represent the current lifestyle. Facing this work on the opposite wall is a triptych, "Past, Present, and Future", which depicts the historical changes. The other two side walls hang "Night Revels of Lao Li" (2000), a fancy dinner party, "Temporary Ward" (2008), a blood-stained hospital

ward. "New Women" (2000), an exaggerated fashionista, and "Happy Bodybuilders" (2013), a fetish trove for muscles, look at each other.



The curator Cui Cancan believes that Wang Qingsong's photography never ceases at the functionality of recording facts only. He places doubts, criticisms and ironies into real but suspicious scenes. "He is photographing the idolized images of China. In fact, he stacks a variety of isolated moments infinitely into a history landscape."



New Women, 120x220cm, 2000



On the back of "Question a Brick Wall", two juxtaposed photos of "Buddha with Thousand Hands" provokes the whispers of two students in the audience.

"Requesting Buddha Series No.1" was finished in 1999. The young "Buddha" sits on a Coca-Cola can decorated with flashy colored paper, and his hands reach out for US dollars, CDs, a big brother's mobile telephone, gold ingots and a Kodak film, while his index finger points at a bottle of domestic beer. "Bequeathing Buddha", finished 20 years later, see an "Old Buddha" holding a pork stick bone, a skeleton frame, a smart phone, and a digital camera. In the center of this image, the beer bottle was replaced with a wine bottle.

"From Yanjing Beer to Chateau Lafite Rothschild Wine, a qualitative leap!"

"Is this wine bottle real?" The two students open an online shopping platform and curiously search for authenticity, trying to figure out whether the bottle comes from a seller of bootlegged wine bottles.

In fact, the lobster and stick bones were all bought by his assistant at a market the day before the filming. "The biggest lobster is picked." Chateau Lafite Rothschild Wine is also true, produced in the year when he was born. "My friend gave it to me as a gift when he learnt I need one for my shooting."

The two students glance at the year the photo was taken, and asked each other, "1999, has China joined the WTO?" Then one said, "One photo is called "Requesting Buddha" and the other is called "Bequeathing Buddha". I feel like that I know what he wants to say."

Being too straightforward and vulgar is the first impression some viewers have for Wang Qingsong's works. And he often says, "Don't think too deeply! What you understand is what you see." He never thinks that he was engaged in art. "I am more concerned about reality than artistic forms, because reality affects each of us even if we are indifferent."



Temporary Ward, 170x300cm, 2008

When he first arrived in Beijing in 1993, right after "Deng Xiaoping's southern tour", Wang observed that the world around him changed instantly, e.g., a pack of dried noodles cost from 50 cents to 70 cents, to 90 cents, then 1.1 yuan. Farmers in the villages rushed to build extra houses, covering pigments over brick houses, partitioning into smaller rooms, and putting precast slabs on top for renters from outside the city. Public telephone booths, snack stores, small restaurants were all over places. Taxi cabs were driven around with ornaments in Chairman Mao's image. Revolutionary songs were gently vocalized by sweet female voices after commercial

packaging. The term "a guy with earthly fortune" has not been invented, while nouveau riche with the same meaning has been widely sprouting.

He couldn't see it through, but felt something was wrong. During that period, he painted many oil paintings of human bodies intertwined in fist-fighting, or "people wrapped in plastic sheets". By 1994, he was unable to paint any strokes. Over many rounds of chats with Yang Wei, Liu Zheng, Qi Zhilong and Hu Xiangdong every day, he settled with a group of artworks termed as "Gaudy Art" by Li Xianting featuring imagery of radish, cabbage, flashy red and green colors, ceramic cups, and etc. oil on velvet, or occasionally adding some photo collages.



"So tacky," spectators inside and outside the art circle commented. He never refuted. At that time, magazines and monthly calendars were just as fancy and funny. The artist was just satirizing the tacky with its tackiness, a strategy to differentiate himself from the genre of political pop trendy at that time.

It was not very long before his small clique disbanded. The direct portrayal of "gaudy life" slowly developed into his distinctive features as an oil painting artist, which he finally gave up. Since 1996, Wang Qingsong confirmed that photography would be a more "powerful" tool in his art-making.



East and West, Gains and Losses

The motifs of Wang Qingsong's long-term concern is mutual scrutiny, imitation, and collision between the East and the West in terms of exchanges in materials and culture. This process develops from coherence to conflict.

In his early works, certain global commercial brands were either worshipped or targeted. The shame of being joked, disdained, and "trampled" is ready to burst out of the scarred body.

When he went abroad for the first time in 1997, he landed in UK for a solo exhibition. Unable to speak a word of English, he had to go to McDonald's to grab a bite. After he entered the store, several plumbers in suits came here too. They ate happily and didn't care about their dirty clothes at all. Wang Qingsong was shocked.

He couldn't forget his first time of eating hamburgers at McDonald's in Beijing three years ago, when invited by a friend,. They spent a huge sum of money, more than two hundred yuan, and chatted more than four hours. "That was probably the first McDonald's opened in China. It has

two floors on Wangfujing Street and 40,000 people went to eat on the first day." He took it for granted that McDonald's was a luxurious Western restaurant.



Along with overseas experience, Wang Qingsong seemed to sniff out something. He would laugh if someone had a birthday party in McDonald's with cheerful background music. The first time he tasted Coca-Cola, he felt like swallowing horse urine. Later, it became his habit to drink a large bottle of coke every day. Further on, his teeth were a little loose. It was worth mentioning that many huge eye-catching advertisements of real estate projects selling houses and apartments with a pseudo-foreign name attracted his attention. He attributed them together as "false modernity."

In "Competition" (2004), he uses ink, brushes, and markers to write poster-like advertisements and set up chaotic scenes of an "advertising battle". In "Romantique" (2003), he creates a misty and flourishing forest paradise. Naked models are like angels or ladies in famous paintings, numb with clumsy movements and dull expressions. They are "grafted" absurdly into the wonderful painting classics.



Romantique, 120x650cm, 2003

Those younger generation born after 1995, after seeing his exhibition, would ask this question in surprise, “Is it overreacting and treating the West (the West material world) as an imaginary enemy?” This divergence from younger generations and collectivist aesthetics from his generation are exactly two sides of one coin in his works. Wang Qingsong does not deny the generational imprints unable to be erased from his body.

"I go to Chairman Mao's Memorial every 10 years. It is not for worship, but a habit. Although the epoch brought too much confusion between black and white, right and wrong, my memories during growth in youth cannot be erased." For others who listened to the song "On the Field of Hope" in the 1980s., either it is encouraging or outdated, Wang felt just right because he lost his father at that time which dragged him out of a deep valley.



Another Battle Series No.6, 180x120cm, 2001

Time flies. A few years later, the commander in "Another Battle series" (2001) who was bandaged to take over the highland, has a mixed feeling of love and hate for his "enemy". The photo work "Question a Brick Wall" (2020), completed in the first half of 2020, is also a composition of logos on the Fortune 500 list. The doubts and objections in the early years have turned into calm questions. Wang Qingsong, the thinker hiding in the dot of the question mark, does not bear any sadness or righteous indignation as in the past.



"Western consumer culture has really changed a lot of our concepts. Traces of destroying tradition are penetrating everywhere. However, it seems inseparable from our everyday life. Look at this pandemic. There are few choices for dining except those well-known western fast food restaurants." Standing in front of the installation of "Question a Brick Wall", Wang sighed.

Speaking of this vulgar and fat "Buddha" with hands stretching into the air, one sees a lot more divisions, revelations, castrations, and hybridization through displaced statues of saints, cigarette cases, and a face in the broken mirror.

"It's hard to tell what kind of person this is. In fact, each of us benefits a lot from this commercialization and neither of us can be completely isolated from the outside world. You see

what he throws (to the ground) is what he takes. What he obtained were thrown back to the garbage dump."

In this contemporary art world, Wang feels exactly the same.



He has met several Western curators who know and love his work, including Francois Hebel, the artistic director of Rencontre de la Photographie Arles. "Some curators in the West also hope to showcase wonderful works to resist Western centralism. They like to find something vigorous and vibrant in other places."

But he gradually felt that as he won awards at the international photography festivals, "hostility" from the West was also growing. "When you are very weak, they are willing to help you. At a certain point, if you are better than their western photographers, they will never believe you. Some even try to stop you. Think about this more seriously! At the beginning, we learned only the surface, or even misunderstood the West. After a long time, we reflect on this learning process, finding it colliding with our own foundation. Nowadays, the younger generation goes

out early and may have learned the best of the West. But learning, I am afraid, will be at a loss afterwards. So, what should we do next?"



A Photograph that Changes Destiny

“Night Revels of Lao Li”, made in 2000, was probably the work that best appropriates a tradition classical piece and wins him the most applause. This work, nearly aborted, became a turning point in Wang Qingsong's half century's life journey.

The photo imitates Gu Hongzhong's "Night Revels of Han Xizai", with five scenes assembled into a long scroll. Only a pipa was replaced by a guitar and Han Xizai's hand-washing was changed to Li Xianting's foot-washing. No real washing foot of course. The pair of socks was still on Lao Li's feet.

In Wang Qingsong's view, at the turn of the century while the economy was booming, and personal wealth surging, traditions faded out and new things kept emerging. The entangled concerns of intellectuals were very similar to Han Xizai's unease in the Southern Tang Dynasty.

"Are the times getting better or worse? Where are your ambitions? What are you going to produce for this society?"

Originally, he wanted to invite his friend Lao Guo (Yiling) to play the role of Han Xizai, but he felt that Lao Guo was a bit like a gangster. Then he thought about Xiao Feng, but Xiao's beard was just not right. Li Xianting recommended himself, "Should I come?"

"Okay." Wang Qingsong was pleased, but he did not reveal his shooting details, fearing that Lao Li would object.



The elegant and slender lady singers in the original painting were played by some women with fat waists and legs in his photograph, stretching in a pom-pom tank top and spotted stockings, holding a rose red feather fan, pedaling red slippers, in red, yellow, blue and green wigs, as colorful as cockscomb feathers. The looks in their eyes were even more stunning. So dumb!

Lao Li was a little confused after attending a friend's birthday party the night before. Unexpectedly, this look fit well with the expression of "sorrow" and exhaustion that Wang Qingsong wanted.

When Lao Li saw these models, unprepared, he asked Wang Qingsong secretly, "Where did you find these people? So outlandish?" Wang Qingsong explained that these were just models. Lao Li thought about it, looked at the "combination", and felt "quite interesting".

"To change to foot washing is also very good. Because washing hands will block the view of people behind. As Lao Li's feet were washed, the people in front row squat down and the blocking problem was solved." Wang Qingsong was very satisfied.

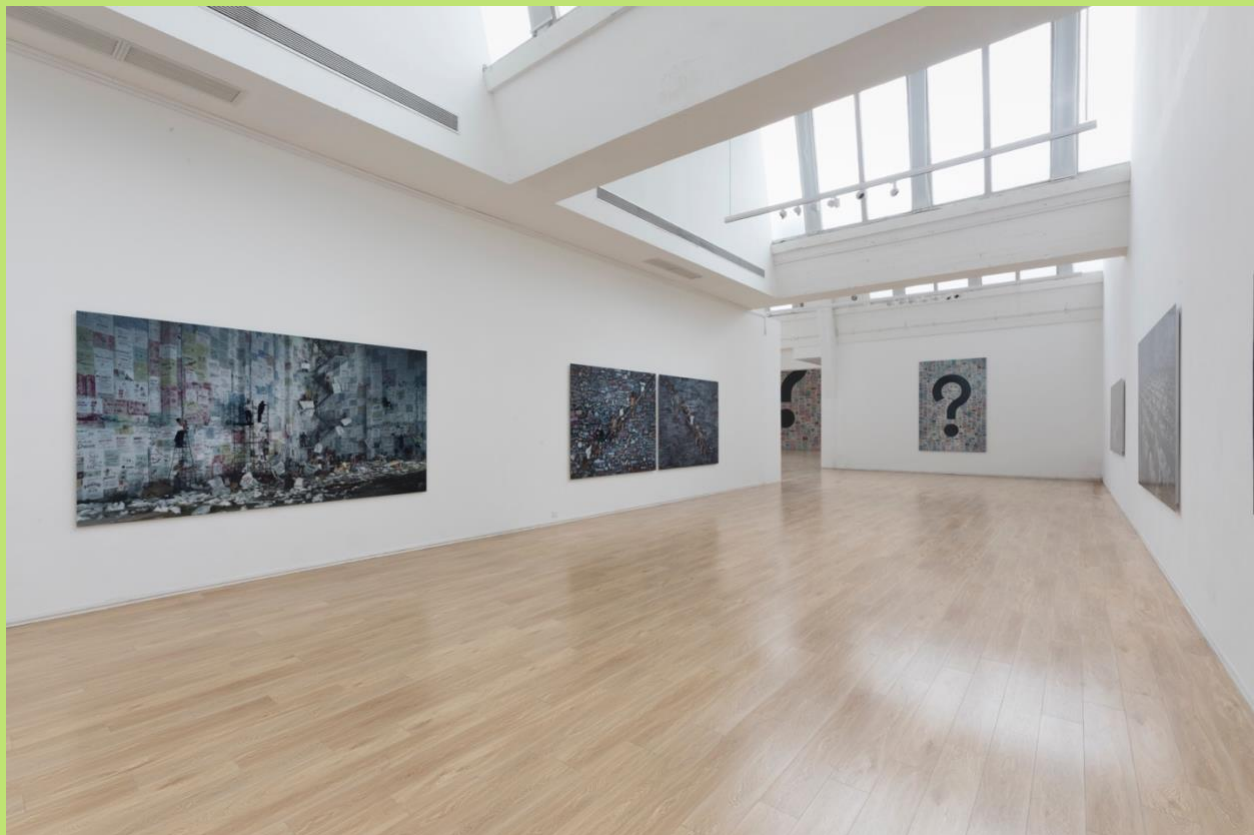


It was only an hour before the end that Wang discovered that the "photographer reversely installed the film". When Wang Qingsong saw the final rescued film, he felt reassured that fortunately he asked for a reshoot.

A few days later when he was developing photos, some painting friends asked him to go for a dinner. They said, "hey, hurry up! Come to eat. What the heck you take photographs? When I unrolled the film at the dinner table, I felt a very obvious expression on their faces. Damn! This bullshit made it! They froze stiff! It was such a long film! Plus, Lao Li participated in such a big

performance. It means that at least (Wang Qingsong) this guy has already made a leap forward. Many foreigners who saw the photo later were also surprised because it was the first time some one in China used scattered perspectives to shoot a scroll. As for the cultural background, they have no clue whatsoever."

In 2002 Pingyao International Photography Festival, although Wang Qingsong did not win the prize, many directors of photography festivals visited his exhibition and approached him personally. In 2008, the autumn auction at Christie's in London sold his work "Follow Me" for 5,896,500 yuan. Since then, he was nicknamed "China's most expensive photo artist".



Pain

To date, Wang Qingsong has created only 99 large-format photos, an average of no more than 5 works per year. He always conceives of the text or picture first, then draws the sketches, designs poses, postures, and costumes for a few up to hundreds of characters. Then he finds the location

to shoot, construct stage sets, prepare for all props, and try to add more ideas into each step of this whole process.

Until the scenes are set for shooting, "subtraction" begins during rescheduling. The height of the camera and the composition of the photograph must be determined by the artist. Usually he won't tell models who the director is and what ideas the director wants to achieve in case more and more "commerce-driven" models raise their prices mid-way. Such lessons teach him a hard way. If there are such emergencies, certain people and installations can be removed to ensure that the shooting takes place. Usually he must prepare two to four films for each work. Next, he will scan the positives as large as one gigabyte before printing out the work. "My photography reflects on the issues from this commercial era. So, its quality of texture cannot be worse than it."

Unlike the usual photojournalism series, what Wang Qingsong does is to concentrate on the changes and conflicts in one single photograph. "Traditional photographers may take 20 to 30 years. But I will analyze what these 20 to 30 years happened. I want to check on a lot of information and reveal the authenticity with one single film."

"Follow Me" was a TV show that swept the country in the 1980s. It was obvious how popular it was to embrace the West by learning English all across this country. Wang Qingsong's photo with the same title was created out of an unintentional "promise."

"At that time, a friend of mine filmed a lot. Every weekend, he would spend lots of money in shooting pictures. I said to him, "I would film only one which will definitely be cheaper than yours, but not worse than yours." Wang Qingsong put up a piece of plaster board, 4 meter high, 8 meter long. Using ink to blacken the board, writing with colored chalks costing 3 yuan only, he covered the whole blackboard with both Chinese and English quotations, slogans about SARS, World Expos, Biennales and other current worldwide events. The contents covered his lived experiences in the last decades. He said to his students, "If you don't have money, then you have your time. Time is the most needed cost in this era."

In shooting "Follow Him", the books were purchased from a junkyard, weighing more than 20 tons. Unloaded one by one from the truck, they were, with dust, placed on the bookshelf to be sprayed with water and rice soup later for moist and mold, He waited for months. "It was

summer, and the books were more prone to mold due to moisture. This would show the shabbiness in the photograph. The staid old man in the reading room (played by Wang Qingsong) finished reading thousands of books, and still didn't know what knowledge is really about. What is the purpose of reading them?"



Follow Him, 130x300cm, 2009

During the six months of lockdown due to Coronavirus, he spent four months depicting hundreds of corporate and institutional advertisements in "Question a Brick Wall". Sitting on the cloth sofa, he worked as long as 10 hours to finish only 3 sheets every day. When painting, his legs were folded and spread out on a stool. His head lay over the table diagonally. At the end of the day, his hands were shaking and back aching.

Take the poster he made of Tate Modern in U.K. as an example. Each letter consisted of numerous small circles. He carefully sketched out the contours, traced the shapes, and painted each one of them with colors. In some cases, he needed to outline them again. When these posters were pasted on a seven or eight-meter-high wooden board, it was almost impossible to see the difference between a thinly painted dot and a directly printed dot.

"No assistant?"

He smiled. "Where can I find someone during the pandemic? The only assistant is busy looking up information, printing logos, and doing other tasks. Besides, I have to do this all by myself."

Starting from "Competition" in 2004, he must do it himself when it comes to painting.

"I have always said that I make photo works like producing compressed biscuits. If the work is achieved by the team via a lot of money, it will become more and more alienated from the artist. And I believe when I paint, there is another eye watching me. Nowadays, watching many blockbuster movies does not exert any feelings on audience. Why? Because even if he was punched very harshly, he flew up to dozens of meters, fell down, but still alive. It is very exciting, but there is no pain. We still hope to see shots like in "Shaolin Temple", that one is bleeding after being beaten up with one heavy fist."



Iron Man, diptych, 150x120cm x 2 pieces, 2008, also a video, 4 mins, 35mm, 2008

Wang rarely does post-production for his photo works. Over these years, the most important post-processing is to reduce the saturation by 30% to 50% before printing final photographs.

Although gorgeous colors and desires are still there, these works carry more gloomy and sad mood.



Skyscraper, 120x225cm, also a video, 5', 35mm, 2008

In 2008, Wang Qingsong shot three short films. In filming "Skyscraper" at a rural village of Changping Township, in the suburbs of Beijing, he directed workers to build a "skyscraper" with a scaffolding structure of 50 meters in diameter and 38 meters in height. The video recorded the time-lapse process of laying the foundation, erecting, completing and celebrating this empty structure. In the accompaniment of "Silent Night", a Christmas carol, clusters of fireworks were blossoming on its "top".

In "123456 Chops", a mysterious man in a sick patient garment threw a dead sheep on a chop board. With only one dimmed lamp, he spent 10 hours to dismember the sheep into minced meat. In "Iron Man", a man, wearing a seafaring T-shirt, is beaten up by countless heavy punches from different directions. He dodged and confronted. He bled all over his face (a makeup effect). Until his teeth and hair fell off, this iron man smiled at the end at his opponent.



123456 Chops, 120x200cm, also a video, 4', DV, 2008

In Cui Cancan's interpretation, the emptiness, depression, and fear in these works convey the common dilemma of everyone at the moment. "In terms of changes in subject matters or value orientation, Lao Wang has been more vague than ever before. The pop song "On the Field of Hope" inspired him in his youth. Today, many people lose their coordinates. Where is the hope for the future? No one can give this revelation. Reality makes Wang suddenly realize that it is no longer possible to make a simple response like 20 years ago. Relying solely on photography may not be sufficient to express his meanings."

Forever an outsider

The exhibition is being installed on the day of the interview. Wang Qingsong clung to his flip-flops. Dressed in dark camouflage pants, he does not match the nickname of "art nouveau".

Looking at himself in "Bequeathing Buddha", he laughs at himself, "He's much more greasy with 40 kilos heavier than before. You see (raising his hand)! The arms changed directly from a shrimp to a crab! Ha-ha!"

But he is so proud of himself that many stronger people fail to beat him in wrist contest.

"True Gig" comes from his early life in the drilling career.

Born in Daqing, he returned to his hometown with his father who worked in Jiangnan Oilfield. After graduating from high school, he took up his father's job and worked in the drilling team for seven years.

On a shift of 12 people, his everyday life was to drill wells, change drill pipes, and repair parts. From 4 a.m. to 4 p.m., he worked for 12 hours, staring at the machine constantly.

There is no touching story of "tempering his will", but the deep scar came from "the aftermath of fear for accidents". He can't forget that a worker, accidentally mistaken the clutch when lifting the drill pipe, was swept to death by unhooked iron bump (ring). Or his colleagues, during welding things, touched upon water, and hands were electrocuted. From then on, he would go around the telephone pole when it rained.

Later both parents were transferred to Jiangnan Petroleum Institute. His father cared the flower garden at a service company, and his mother painted the classroom tables and chairs. Inexplicably, he became interested in painting, and staggered to get into Sichuan Academy of Fine Arts.

In 1993, Wang Qingsong came to Beijing by bus holding 1,200 yuan. This newcomer to Beijing wrote three diaries on a hard-cover notebook, documenting his Journey to the North." He dreamt to make a big deal." After three diariess, he wrote no more. How Stupid! "Lao (old) Wang" laughed at "Little Wang".



Past, Present and Future, 175cm×(291cm+281cm+291cm), triptych, 2001

During the winter, he lived nearby the Old Summer Palace. He bought 200 kilos of Chinese cabbage for 20 yuan as buying in bulk was cheaper. He almost threw up as he ate too much cabbages. The rooftop near his bed leaked. The rain poured in. He must bear with the trembling roof. Later, he moved from the Fragrant Hills, to East Dongbai River, and then to Songzhuang. He never felt settled. In one year, he had to move 5 times. "As long as someone makes a higher bid, the landlord will kick us out. Sometimes if I don't pay attention, my belongings will be stolen. Local villagers are not friendly to us."

One time during the New Year, he really wanted to visit Lao Li (Li Xianting)'s house. "Looking at a box of oranges costing 15 yuan, I hesitated as I have only a few dozen yuan left. Forget it, I won't go."

When he finally entered Lao Li's house, Lao Li pointed to his sofa and told him that Luo Zhongli, Wang Guangyi, and Fang Lijun all slept in the sofa. "I was so excited when I heard that. Imagine myself to be one of them in the future. But I did not have anything. Lao Li said to me, "if you don't have any money, come here and have a bowl of noodles. It doesn't matter. "

But no one can depend on big brother forever.

Before shooting "Night Revels of Lao Li", walking back home with a bag of props, he was stopped by the "police".

"I told them I was a teacher at the Central Academy of Fine Arts. I live in a place 20 meters away. One person said, "just you, a teacher of the Academy of Fine Arts?" They figured out I was not from Beijing as I had a strong accent and pushed me into a minivan. Many people squat as the back seat was completely dismantled. I'm the last one to come in. He told us we would be

sent to Changping County for turning over sand for construction plants. After we make enough money for a return train ticket, we will be sent back to where we come from. “However, if any of you can turn in 200 yuan, you can leave right away.” Holy Crap! I took out 200 yuan from my butt pocket and gave it to him. He said me, “Fuck off”.

Since then, Wang Qingsong never felt at ease if he went out alone.

"That's why I had this hairstyle." Wang Qingsong pointed to his head with “wild grass.” "When someone sees my hair like this, he thinks I am really sick. I might have cancer or something serious. So, he won't ask any more."

This trick actually worked. The chance of being stopped and questioned is greatly reduced.

"We saw his head, all laughed hilariously. This is it! The only one." He Yunchang, a longtime friend and performance artist, smiled and stopped. "When we first met Qingsong, all of us were very arrogant and motivated, thinking in our hearts that the future belongs to us. It's that simple. The earth is under our feet. Now Look at his hair. It hides the artist's wisdom and helplessness. This society is so unreliable.

After this "trial", Wang Qingsong further strengthened his faith of "creeping forward", a strategy he followed since he moved to Beijing. "I have just arrived and don't know anyone. I must move forward. If not, there will be no chance. But one has to lie on his stomach and crawl forward. Don't raise your head."

In 2007, he rented a 400-square-meter studio in Caochangdi for 20 years. That money could buy a big house in Wangjing Area. He felt secure with this studio, reassuring him that he was lucky in the end. Even if life is full of variables, anyone can be overruled by a minor mistaken presumption.

The caution and anxiety brewed from life experiences linger on, ceaseless like the increasing wrinkles on his forehead.



Zong Ning and Wang Qingsong

After shooting the last negative of “Question a Brick Wall”, Wang Qingsong was in a great mood. Hence this working photo. As this new work was created indoors. Without models, it is much easier to control. He felt more relaxed. Shooting a lot of works which require outdoor sets, construction, communication, model management and etc. is very demanding, tiring and frustrating as many situations pop up.

Fate

After shooting each work, the team would celebrate and have fun for a big meal. Each time, Wang Qingsong prefers to smoke a cigarette, stay quiet and fall asleep. Once the tension and excitement in the early stage are released, the sense of overdraft will suddenly hit. Probably because of his coming age, fatalism is haunting.

He often thought of his father, mother, and younger brother. None of the three walked away peacefully, out of expectation.

When he was a child, he never called his dad. He had a dark complexion. He felt because he was ugly, therefore his father disliked him. When the father came back from the night shift from the drilling field, he saw his oncoming son. Wang would turn his back and pretended not to see his father. "He keeps saying to me that I am finished, and this kid will be hopeless."

When he was 14 years old, Wang had so many grudges against many things. His dad was so angry that he beat him and went out to work. Back home again, he returned as one dead body from a car accident on a business trip. Separated by Yin and Yang from his dad, Wang Qingsong's youthful rebellion stopped abruptly.

"When my father was cremated, the funeral staff used tongs to stoke the fire. The body was burned into half a skeleton. Suddenly, I saw my dad sitting up. At that moment, my soul was taken."

After his father passed away, his mother was in a bad mood. Once she scolded him. In the middle of the night, he ran to the moat of Jingzhou, and walked into the river. When the water reached his chest, he suddenly heard a frog's "quacking". He returned to his consciousness.

When shooting "Night Revels of Lao Li", he had a very hard life and his creativity faced a challenge too. He took the compensation money from his mother's death, salaries from the last few months, and intended to make a desperate move. It wasn't until the last shot was finished and the film sheet couldn't be taken out that he realized the negative was reversely loaded. "But at any rate it's reshot. I think because I was using my mother's compensation money, this money will not be wasted. The deceased's money shouldn't be taken away. If installed reversed and not retaken, it will definitely be doomed for failure."

The death of his mother finally assured Wang Qingsong that he needed a settlement. He got married, had children, and did not migrant anywhere.

But it is strange that he never dreamed of his father and mother. "I always want to have a dream of what they would tell me. But I could have all sorts of dreams but I never have any dream about my parents. Are they angry with me or what? I don't know."

He Yunchang said that Wang Qingsong was very generous and kind who puts his family on his top priority. "So he will struggle with these concerns. However, a powerful artist will eventually detach himself and realize he should rise above himself and convert his role into an artistic creator."

Is Wang Qingsong detached? He is fascinated with Dante's "Divine Comedy". What does heaven and hell look like? He always wants to shoot this subject matter. But he never has the chance. He says, "As long as people live, they will suffer. No one can be exempted. Social changes happen on the surface level. It is difficult to express what is really inside even if its impact is palpable. I often feel that the moment one creates art at the earliest time is the one moment when he leaves this world. The power of art refers to that feeling for life."

"One day, I will shoot "The Divine Comedy"." As he said, he squeezes out the cigarette in his hand.



王庆松
WANG QINGSONG

在希望的田野上

ON THE FIELD OF HOPE

策展人 崔灿灿

CURATOR CUI CANCEAN

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